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Virginia Mayhew

Virginia Mayhew has led a diverse career as a saxophonist, composer, and band leader. She has performed with Diva, Al Grey, and Claudio Roditi, and has recorded extensively as a leader and proponent of her own jazz compositions.

Virginia was interviewed via Zoom on May 23, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Virginia Mayhew with me, saxophonist and composer, and I hear you do karate as well.

VM: I do. I've been doing karate a long time. It's been life changing actually. I've been doing it since I first moved to New York so that's over thirty years.

MR: When we were trying to decide a time to meet I recall that maybe the first time I suggested happened to be in the morning. And you said, "Well I could but I like to practice." And I had two reactions. First of all, good for you; and second of all like I should do that more myself.

VM: Well I mean I'm a working musician so I mean I have to practice and I just find that the earlier part of the day I'm more focused, I have more energy and then I'm not thinking about oh my God, I've got to practice all day long. So I practice and then on a good day I'll get in there and I'll do some more stuff or arranging or whatever. But the morning, early part of the day up 'til maybe 2:00 is the best time for me.

MR: Can you tell me if you practice now is it considerably different than it might have been fifteen or twenty years ago?

VM: My personal practicing?

MR: Yes. On the saxophone.

VM: Fifteen or twenty years ago — I would say generally it's not that much different. I do some stuff to get my air and my sound going and I do some technical stuff and then I work on music. So it's the same general — I mean what I work on might be different depending on what I have coming up, but why do you think that?

MR: Well I'm a — when I am motivated to practice it usually for me is something like you just mentioned — what's coming up. Like I have to get beyond motivated, I might be panicky.

VM: I try to avoid panicky but it does happen.

MR: Yes. And do you also practice your karate at home?

VM: I do. I have no been practicing as much karate as I would like for the last few years

MR: Yes.

VM: And ever since I moved out to Jersey from the City it's been — I used to practice karate all the time and it's been harder since I've been out here but I've done better. I'm just getting back to it now because my folks died unfortunately, so getting back to my life. And that's a big part of it.

MR: Okay. I'd like to read a paragraph here and perhaps you have a comment or reaction to it. This is from Steve Fudderman who wrote for "Night Life."

VM: In the *New Yorker*.

MR: Yes.

VM: I was so happy. Go ahead.

MR: Okay. It says, "With few guarantees of either recognition or fortune, the life of a serious jazz instrumentalist is a saga of fortitude. Virginia Mayhew, a post-bop saxophonist and composer of obvious depth and feeling has bobbed and weaved through the musical trenches for four decades now, accruing respect from her peers and offering pleasure to those who have become acquainted with her artistry." And then it goes on to say your upcoming gig at Small's, which "helps keep the heart of mainstream jazz beating, much like Mayhew herself."

VM: Wow. You know I sent him a message immediately because for two reasons. First of all he totally gets it, and second of all because all the years that I've been here I've never gotten mentioned in the *New Yorker*. And it's like, it's not really a big deal obviously but I was so happy. And I have a friend who's 94 and she gets the *New Yorker* and she's always reading it, and finally she saw my name there with a good little blurb so it was wonderful on so many levels.

MR: I hope you cut it out, because I would have.

VM: Well I have it on my computer. Maybe I'll print it up so I'll have a back-up copy. But that was just — I was so happy to get that. I've had a few things like that happen in the last year or so. It's — ah — just when you need it, a little, somebody gets it and it really, the timing has been good.

MR: I'd like to focus on two terms he used, "mainstream" and "post-bop." He called you a post-bop saxophonist, which I don't think you'd necessarily argue with as far as a timeline, but do you describe your playing with terms like that? If you could write a review of yourself what terms would you use to describe your playing?

VM: Well I had a friend doing my website and PR stuff for many years, Deb Lake, and she came up with a little blurb to go with me and with my label Renma Recordings, and she said, "jazz with a twist." So it's pretty straight-ahead but we're not playing standards all the time and we're not playing, you know, other people's arrangements, and I think with

tricky thing. But when I think of mainstream I think of not really what's happening now in jazz, with all the young people. And I'd love to talk to you about all that also, but I mean I'm not a free player, but I'm not totally mainstream. But I have elements of mainstream. So that's what I really like when she said, "jazz with a twist." It's — like we play songs, whether they're originals or whatever, with melodies and it's just — but then we do things like some odd meters and the last chunk of years I've been playing a lot more with my old friend Roberta Pickett. Do you know her?

MR: I saw that, one of the videos.

VM: Incredible pianist and musician. And she uses all these weird chords. And so I did a recording project with her a few years ago, the music of Marian McPartland. Did you hear that?

MR: Yeah. Mary Lou Williams?

VM: I did Mary Lou. She did Marian McPartland. And so she writes all these weird chords so I was just writing a tune this week and I started to really hear those weird chords. So I'm always trying to grow, you know, with the harmony and the rhythm — you know, odd meters and everything.

MR: Do you have perfect pitch?

VM: I do not.

MR: Nor do I. And when I am playing with a pianist especially who uses what — I will use your term also, sort of weird chords, do you have a way of finding your way in them?

VM: Well it depends if I have a chance to work on the stuff, which I did with Roberta's music. So I would sit at the piano and I would play those chords and I would see what do I hear over that. And I had to do it chord by chord because there are so many of them. But I'm starting to hear them now and if I don't have that, like recently I did a rehearsal with Billy Mintz — do you know him? A great drummer? And he has this tune, it's really hard. Anyhow, it's just really hard tune — and he said, "Don't look at the chord changes, don't think about the chord changes, just play." And if I don't know what's going on with the harmony on that kind of stuff I just play, you know, and try to make melodies and create something. Because you can't, unless they're playing one of those chords for a long time you can't really catch it. I mean what's your experience with that?

MR: Well I find that I probably avoid the situations.

VM: I like to put myself in challenging situations. I think that might come from my karate training. Maybe not, I don't know. Maybe not. But I like to be challenged. Not that I'm not challenged by anything, but I like to really throw myself into the deep end. And fortunately I have friends and peers that like to do that.

MR: I have a brief anecdote. I got to know Marian McPartland many years ago, and when she

something like well do you have any requests for the concert tonight? And I don't know why I said this, "Well what about playing something free?" So she did, and then the other day I was listening to you as her guest and you played something free.

VM: Did we?

MR: You did. And so I wondered how that felt? Do you remember it?

VM: I have no memory of that at all. I hadn't done very much free playing at that point or still, and what I do remember is the mouth on her. Did you experience that?

MR: Yes.

VM: I mean you hear [mimics] "Marian McPartland" you know and she's all proper and everything, but in the studio when we recorded that I could not believe the things coming out of her mouth, it was so great. And then she'd get back on the mic all proper and everything. It was so funny. I don't remember that. I need to dig that up.

MR: Listen to it, yeah, and it's funny because at the end of it she said something like, "Well you really can't go wrong with this."

VM: Playing free?

MR: Yes. And it's interesting because sometimes I could, I was putting myself in your place and I could hear you sort of trying to find out where is she, or maybe I won't even try to find out.

VM: I have no memory at all but I do know that I certainly wasn't comfortable.

MR: Well it begs the question, and I often times ask this one, the question is are there wrong notes in improvising for you?

VM: I think it's a matter of the music that you're playing and your intent. Because you can hit, I mean if you're playing something that's really inside, to me it sounds sort of weird unless you were playing like maybe you're playing some sort of idea that you're in and then you take it out and then you come back in. But if you just play one note that's really sticking out there and then you don't — like I don't know if you've ever done this, you play something — oh I'm not sure about that. And then instead of just running you try to incorporate that. Play it some more times or develop it into something different. But the better, the older and better I get I realize like Monk said, there aren't really any wrong notes, depending — for me — adding depending on the intent. You know you really want to hear that major third over a minor triad? I mean I really like the way it sounds if you go from the minor to the major and back to the minor, it creates dissonance. But if you're playing in a minor blues and you keep playing the major third, like just in your lines and stuff, that would bother me.

MR: I agree. You usually can sort of tell if people are doing it on purpose rather than they don't know that it's sort of not working.

MR: Yes. I'd like to try — I've never actually asked this question specifically of anybody so I'm going to try it out on you. Let's suppose there's a little scenario and we meet at a cocktail party and I'm like an investment banker. And I ask you, "Well Virginia, what do you do for a living?" And you say, "Well I'm a jazz musician." And I say, "Well how do you play jazz?"

VM: How do you play jazz?

MR: How do you play jazz?

VM: Let's get another drink. I mean to play — to do anything well takes years and years. I mean how do you play jazz. You mean the process? Or what is taking this guy —

MR: My question — it's a ridiculous question.

VM: It's broad.

MR: Yes it's way too broad. All right. So he continues to say "Well I kind of like jazz I've heard except when they do that thing where they're just — I guess they're just making it up. How does that work? I don't get it."

VM: I guess I would ask him, "Are you talking about after the melody in general?" It happens all the time. Or are you talking about a kind of music that what we call free music where there isn't really any set plan. And I guess depending on if he could answer that question I would go in a direction.

MR: "Well yes I heard a group playing 'My Funny Valentine' and I liked it and then I didn't know, how do they know when to stop and the other person plays."

VM: Yes. I've been asked that before, of course. And so I would explain that there's a form to the song, it's a certain number of, a certain amount of time you do this and then there's another certain amount of time you do this, and everybody knows, and there are different things that happen during that. I mean I don't think I would even say chords, you know, it sounds like he would be pretty clueless. Different things happen but everything happens in a set time. So that's going on all during the song. And if you sing the melody of the song while that's happening you should be able to tell, you know, you should come out the same place that they do when they come back and play the melody again.

MR: All right.

VM: I mean I've been asked that question and it's really just a matter of how long do you want to talk to this person about it.

MR: Yes. And then you think, yes, I think I will go get another drink.

VM: No I mean if they really seem like they're interested then it'll go on longer. I mean I always try to answer, I always try to be nice and answer people's questions as best I can.

MR: Sure. And some things aren't — I think some things aren't necessarily answerable. With improvisation, for me there's a bit of magic to it that is not explainable and I don't mind

VM: Definitely there's magic when it's happening.

MR: Let me take you back a little bit. I understand you come from a musical family — your grandparents were classical musicians and they supported — am I correct that they supported your career even though they didn't understand it?

VM: Yes. My grandfather said to me once, you know, "I worry about you playing this jazz music" you know, "there are drugs and alcohol" and you know, "why don't you get a job like in a symphony or something?" And I told him that this is the music I really love. And they were both very broad-minded and the fact that it was music, even though they didn't get it, it was music and I was obviously serious. Whenever I was there I would be practicing a lot, it was a great place to practice. And so they knew I was serious and they respected that enough to say okay we want to support this.

MR: I think the term "get it" is very interesting because I could respect what they're doing but if they're playing a piece by Schoenberg or something I'm going to say, "I don't get it."

VM: Yup. Yup. Definitely.

MR: You don't necessarily have to enjoy something, quote, to get it.

VM: Absolutely. Absolutely. But I think if you, once you get it you're going to enjoy it a lot more.

MR: Speaking of getting it, I see on your quote resume, that when you were still on the West Coast you did some work with Frank Zappa. Is that correct?

VM: Yes. The Berkley, California Symphony commissioned him. This is a great story. They commissioned him to write a symphony or whatever. And in my opinion he listened to all the modern cats and then he brought in this — actually I was playing saxophone with it, and I had never — excuse me — played with a symphony orchestra. So I got the music ahead and I'm practicing and it's like all this multi-polyrhythmic stuff. Like it would be in 3/4 it would be four over three and then within that there would be some triplets, and things were tied, and some of it was not really in the ideal range, and it was really, really, really hard. And I worked my tail off on it. And my feeling — I shouldn't say this, I'm going to get myself in trouble again — was I just felt like he listened to a bunch of this modern music and somehow stuck it all together and I had no emotional — it just felt like sort of like he was just trying to impress somebody. But the good part, the best part of the story is at our dress rehearsal my roommate's parents came. They're from Missouri. And so we started rehearsing and all of a sudden out on the stage come these huge, like maybe eight or ten foot high penises. [scats] And it turned out this was basically a pornographic puppet show. So my friend's mother grabbed the father and took him out of there right away. It was so funny.

MR: Oh you are correct, it makes for a great story. Gee I wonder how soon they booked Frank

VM: Oh they lost their shirt on that because that was a great symphony orchestra and they played a little bit brave but mostly straight ahead and this just was complete — they lost their base.

MR: I see.

VM: It's too bad.

MR: Yeah I saw him in 1968 I think and I just — he — it was with the Mothers of Invention and I'm sure I was impressed but at the same time confused.

VM: Yeah I don't get it, as we were saying, but I know there must be something there because I have friends that think he's really great. Do you know Ed Palermo?

MR: I do not.

VM: He's a saxophone player/composer/arranger. He has a band. He's been doing Frank Zappa music for decades. And he's a really good musician. So I know that there's something there that I'm missing but I don't know what it is.

MR: When you sit down, after you've practiced your saxophone and— do you have to be in a mood to compose?

VM: Definitely.

MR: And what kind of mood is that?

VM: I mean it depends, just — usually what happens is I start hearing something and so then I go and figure it out.

MR: Do you go to the piano or do you pick up your saxophone?

VM: Well if I'm practicing or something then I'll mess around with it for a while but then I'll go to the piano and try to figure out, you know try to write down what I'm hearing. So yeah it's definitely — there's something different. When I'm writing there's a different feeling. There's a reason that I go to write. I'm not just like a professional composer who sits down every morning and starts writing whether it's good or bad.

MR: I read something about your compositional reaction to 9/11.

VM: I don't know that I had one — oh I did, yeah my "Phantoms" album.

MR: Yes.

VM: That was so heavy.

MR: It's an interesting concept to try to capture an event or a really incredibly strong emotion in music.

VM: Well I agree with that. It was really just one tune and it was a tune by Kenny Barron called "Phantoms" and I just felt like I think if we play this rubato — Ingrid Jensen and I were playing a lot together then and we just played this rubato and just — I didn't say anything to them about it but that's sort of what I was going for was phantoms, like what happened that day. But I didn't write a whole project about it and I didn't really set out to

MR: Did you have a number of — I can remember specific recordings when I was younger that I didn't know the term "epiphany" yet, but they gave me one.

VM: Yes.

MR: And did you have a similar experience?

VM: I did, several. The first one I would say would be when I heard one of — when I heard Dexter Gordon. Because he was so melodic and he was so swinging, and that's what I responded to. And then the next time I still remember it, I was playing along with this, it was when I was a lead alto player and I was playing along with a Count Basie record and I don't know, it think it was Willie Smith, the lead alto, he had a high B flat, just the one on top of the staff, and I finally got the alto sound I'd been trying to get from that one note, just hearing that one note. I kept playing it over and over, the recording, just because he had a [scats] it was exactly the sound I was trying to get. And that was amazing. And then some Coltrane things that I heard were pretty amazing. So many things in jazz, I mean it's constant. Well not constant but —

MR: My one note, was Cannonball Adderley, when he played "Mercy, Mercy, Mercy" and he went [scats]. I went "Oh, I have to play like that, that one note." Isn't that amazing how that can just like —

VM: Yes. That's exactly the same experience I had. It just resonates I guess.

MR: Yes indeed. Do you try to — I assume you've done some teaching over the years, and how do you pass that magic on? Is there a way you can sort of jumpstart that passion in students?

VM: Well that is my main goal when I'm teaching is to ignite the passion. Because once you have the passion you'll do the work. And so I have my students, always, start having fun in the first lesson. And then we develop it and it depends if it's like a camp that's one thing, or private lessons, but I always start them off doing things that are fun right away, and playing recordings for them so they can hear something besides their lousy school band and playing, maybe playing with them. But I try to have them get the bug. That's my goal.

MR: Yeah that's really important because the school band is what they think of as the norm — or this is what music is supposed to sound like — how are they supposed to go beyond that?

VM: Well they know they like it because they're either taking lessons or at camp or whatever. So they've got a start on it. So I try to get them to expand on that and learn about improvising and just expose them to different music and, but always the technical stuff and well, and the theory. But the bug is the first thing.

MR: Have you had circumstances with students and/or their parents where they ask you about your opinion should I go into a career in jazz, or this is what I'm thinking about? Do you think I should?

VM: I usually give the answer that I heard somewhere along the way which is if you don't have to — like emotionally if you don't have to do it, don't. Because you're never going to hang in there if it's not something that you feel like this is what I'm going to do. If you don't have that kind of attitude you're going to quit I think. So I mean it depends what age you're talking about and if they're getting like high school or whatever — usually the people that ask that are pretty serious. So I had student, a guy who brought me up to Fredonia a few weeks ago, he had been a student right before the pandemic. And he was just this amazing kid and he worked so hard and he was going to be a professional musician and I knew he'd be great because he was so passionate. He was playing bassoon, he was writing arrangements already in high school and practicing. But that's my stock answer. If you don't have to do it for your soul, don't do it. But if you do, do it, it's an amazing life.

MR: I think you answered my next question and that was, was there ever a point where things were harder than usual for a length of time and you considered another profession?

VM: No. Never. But right now I'm not considering another profession, but I'm trying to figure out where I fit in today. Because jazz, the jazz of the people that are 40ish or maybe even 50ish, whenever the jazz schools really got going, the music they're creating, and they're fast becoming the majority if not already, it doesn't have two of the things that I fell in love with jazz, the swing and the blues are pretty much missing. And I'm just trying to figure out where — I'm not going to change who I am or what I do, I'm always trying to grow. But I'm not sure where I'm going to fit in with where it's going now.

MR: You're — it's almost like you're reading my thoughts here because I've been listening not as much as I should but I think what I'm confused about is the time — you know there's a way to play the time and there's a way to play around with the time. And many of the things I hear it's like everybody in the rhythm section is playing around with the time. So where exactly is it? And I guess I'm an old fashioned groove guy. I need — I don't want to think too hard to hear it.

VM: Well it's definitely a different thing. And basically I'm with you but I also love that, but not as a place to live. I like to visit there. And the better I've gotten at it the more fun it is. But I think it's really — it depends on what music you're playing. No that's not true. I don't know. I'm okay with it being more — less rigid. I'm okay with that. I love that too. But I think I know what you're talking about and it's a little too esoteric for you maybe.

MR: Yeah I think it is. I know that the musicians that I've interviewed that were playing in the 40s and 50s, they often would say, "Well today's generation, they all sound the same. They get the books and they learn the licks and then they sound the same."

VM: I agree wholeheartedly. And I think that's really what's happening today. And there are some great musicians but I just don't relate to it. And everybody below the great people, they all sound the same. They go to school and they all learn the same thing, and they all have — I mean this is a gross generalization but it seems like in general they have incredible technique but they don't — just like I said in the beginning they don't have swing and they don't have any blues in their playing. And it's all sort of what you're talking about, sort of a little bit. It's open. And I like it when it's open but not all the time. What do you think? It's an interesting question.

MR: It's an interesting question and I think it has to do partly with jazz, as it should be, as been anointed as an art form now and certainly it should be, and it's embraced by academia, but the thing that happened in smoky night clubs —

VM: They have no experience of that.

MR: Right. And I'm going to jump to this because I watched a couple of videos of you and I'll get this together. When you were talking to Marian McPartland you were talking about different gigs and, "a little club where people aren't really listening" you had addressed some question of hers. And then I watched this thing and you were playing "Body and Soul" in this club and it was so noisy.

VM: I think — was that when George Garzone sat in?

MR: That's when George was there. And I thought it was so interesting because this is reality, ladies and gentlemen.

VM: Well that was reality sometimes. And then you'd be playing at the Kennedy Center the next night.

MR: It's amazing.

VM: And that was a particularly — I wouldn't have kept that except that Garzone was playing. You know, that was especially bad. But that place, The Garage, sometimes it got like that. So I rarely played a ballad there but for Garzone, yeah, that was an extreme situation, that one. But absolutely people talking and drinking and it's, you know, it just depends on the setting — if it's a bar it's a bar, that's what it is. If it's a concert hall nobody better be talking. You know? And some of the clubs like Bradley's and Mezzrow, have you been there?

MR: No.

VM: It's run by Spike Wilner, the same guy that has Small's. And it's a little room. Did you ever go to Bradley's?

VM: Missed out. Bradley's was an amazing little club, it was very small, and that's what this place Mezzrow is like. And they have a no talking policy. So it really depends on the gig. If you're not supposed to talk it bothers me if you're talking. But if it's a gig like that in a bar or something I mean that's what happens. That's the gig. Don't take the gig if you can't deal with that. And you play, I play different music if I'm playing in a situation like that. I mean I might play some of the same music but you have to play — I'll play my music but it's for the audience, I mean, even if they're not listening and they're talking and yelling, something that they will relate to. I don't know, I don't want to sound like I gear my music to the audience but I have a wide range of within what — of me — and so I've done so many of those kinds of gigs over the years I think that that's really helped form who I am as opposed to somebody who hasn't had that experience. You know, blowing gigs.

MR: That's part of being a band leader too is recognizing the situation you're in and making the best possible presentation you can in that surrounding I guess.

VM: Um hum. Are you a band leader also?

MR: I have been, yes. And I was wondering if there are things, I don't know if angry is the right word. Are there things on the bandstand that can aggravate you from —

VM: From the musicians?

MR: Yes, from musicians.

VM: Yes. Well obviously anything musical like they're not listening or they're playing B.S. But I've been really lucky, that hardly ever happens to me. I have this gig at The Garage in the Village for many years and sometimes I'd have to get somebody at the last minute and it's just amazing the great people I could get. Really top shelf people. Everybody just wanted to play. So wait but I lost track of your question.

MR: No, you're answering it, that because you were able to draw from such a large pool of excellent musicians that you probably didn't have those situations very much.

VM: But now, since phones and, if a person pulls out their phone I'm thinking of one particular person that I hired that has done that, that really bothers me. You should not be checking your messages during the bass solo. You know what I mean?

MR: Yes, I'm going to quote you on that.

VM: And [to off camera @ 38:51] just go ahead and put that stuff away.

MR: Wow.

VM: Other than that, as long as everybody's just focusing on the music there's no problem.

MR: What is the average — when you were playing that gig at The Garage do you mind asking me what you were getting paid?

VM: Oh, I don't want to tell you, but I will tell you that it wasn't a lot but it was a good

a little gig like that paid a hundred bucks, that was a pretty good gig, and that's still the case.

MR: And that was in 1987, correct?

VM: Yeah. Talk about the clubs — I think if anything they've gone down, down, down.

MR: Yeah, no inflation going on there with those prices.

VM: For sure.

MR: I understand that you've been like a jazz ambassador to some other countries?

VM: I've done that twice for the State Department and what an amazing experience that was. They send you to someplace sort of off the beaten track. And the first time we went to the newly independent states like Kazakhstan and Moldova, Ukraine, all these places that haven't really experienced jazz except in a lot of these places they have. There'll be like a little contingent of people that love jazz and you know, play, and something like that. And then there'll be all these people that have no idea. But I think it's a really important thing for the United States to send around good will ambassadors like that. And they told us clearly do not talk about politics, but it was — [to off camera 41:01 888] are you almost finished? It was a great experience and I met a lot of people that were — well not a lot but I met some people that played different instruments and they were great musicians, like something called — I think it was called a khene in Laos. I think it was called a ken — k-e-n. And we did something at this little school and this guy sat in, or they played for us, and he was playing some sort of drum thing with — by hand — all sorts of little things. And so we invited him to sit in on a gig. So he brought that and then he also brought this khene thing, which is some sort of bamboo thing. And we started playing a minor blues and he said yeah, yeah. And he played the heck out of that thing. And it was just the most amazing, amazing thing.

MR: Well that comes from a long line of illustrious ambassadors starting with Louis Armstrong and

VM: Ellington.

MR: Ellington, yeah.

VM: Yeah, it was a great honor to do that twice.

MR: Did you take a band?

VM: Yup. The first time it was a trio, Allison Miller and Gary Wang. And the next time it was a quartet with — who did I take — Harvie S., Allison Miller and Daniel Kelley on piano. It was just — that was bossa nova. The first one the theme was Louis Armstrong, the second one the theme was bossa nova, or something, what was it — I think it was bossa nova or something like that. And it was just really, it was so much fun and people just loved it and it was just such an amazing experience to see all these off-the-beaten-path

MR: Let's talk about Al Grey for a minute. He was one of the first people we interviewed way back in '95, and then a couple of years later I happened to go to Sweet Basil's and he was playing there. And he played this tune called "Echoes of New Orleans." It was so catchy. And afterwards I went up to him and I said, "Mr. Grey, that is the coolest tune." And he goes, "Yeah, I got a hit!" And I thought that's so cool that this guy, that he was probably in his late 70s at least, and that he had a hit.

VM: Was it actually a hit or did he think it was a hit?

MR: He thought it was a hit.

VM: Yeah.

MR: Or it was going to be.

VM: Yeah. He was so enthusiastic. What? I'm sorry.

MR: I said it should have been a hit because it was an earworm.

VM: Um hum. I've got to write that down, what was it called?

MR: "Echoes of New Orleans."

VM: "Echoes of New Orleans."

MR: Yeah.

VM: Yeah. He composed a lot of tunes, like simple little tunes, and when I was working with him I would written them down and then write little arrangements for them. And he was always coming up with new things. [to off camera *** 44:22] can you just finish, and go? Thanks. It's so distracting.

MR: That's okay, we can edit that.

VM: And I keep losing my train of thought.

MR: We were talking about Al and his tunes.

VM: Oh Al. Yep. And he would — once he got on stage he was a hundred percent, a hundred percent. And it was a great experience working with him.

MR: Does it make you play better or differently?

VM: What? Because I played with him?

MR: I mean when you were playing with him, did you feel like you changed your own personal style somewhat to —

VM: No.

MR: No?

VM: But he wanted me to play tenor because I was an alto player, and I wasn't playing tenor, and this was right around the same time that that all-female big band Diva was forming, and they wanted me to play tenor. And I'd always been too intimidated by all my great tenor player heroes — to play the tenor. But I thought if people are going to pay me to do this, I'm good. Can you hold on for one second?

[gap @ 45:56 ***]

VM: Okay I'm back.

MR: No problem.

VM: What were we talking about?

MR: We're talk — let's talk about Diva for a minute. I know Sherrie and it's been quite an amazing project.

VM: Twenty-five — let me see — it's over thirty years I think by now. It's been a really important band. I think it brought a number of people in from other countries that were able to get Visas because of it, and it's given a lot of women experience that they wouldn't have gotten otherwise, and created a lot of long term friendships. A lot of people have come through that band.

MR: You made a comment in an article that even though you were told that — no play the clarinet instead, girls don't play the saxophone, that it's better now.

VM: Yes absolutely.

MR: What's the main reason you think that there's been such resistance going back decades, for women to play certain instruments?

VM: The reason?

MR: Yeah.

VM: I mean sexism basically, and you know societal norms of what women can and can't do. Apparently during World War II when all the guys went over to fight, women stepped up and did all those gigs and then I don't know where they came from, they must have already existed. They didn't start from scratch. But then when they came back all the work stopped again. So I think it's a cultural thing and also with wanting to have a family. Or are you talking about elementary school?

MR: No, no, I'm talking about the professional world.

VM: Yeah. Wanting to have a family doesn't — it's a lot better now — people seem to be able to pull it off more, but it's really hard to live that kind of a lifestyle if you want a family with kids, especially when you're young. My friend Ingrid Jensen, who is very successful, she didn't have her child until she was in her 40s and already well established. I just can't imagine how anybody could have a child early unless you have like somebody that's going to stay home and take care of the kid and have a career when you need to be out, in your formative years and stuff like that. Did I get off topic there?

MR: No, you did not. I wonder if you had been offered, before you became a tenor player if you'd been offered to play one of the alto chairs in the Count Basie Orchestra, would you have taken the gig?

VM: Absolutely. Absolutely. Because I was a lead alto player at that time and I would have

MR: Yeah, I've dreamt of it myself.

VM: Are you mostly an alto player?

MR: Yes. What about, and I also saw Junior Mance and Joe Williams on your list. You couldn't play with anybody good, ey?

VM: No. I was so lucky when I first moved to New York. I went to the New School and the faculty was like a Who's Who of living jazz giants, and it was amazing. And that's where I met Norman [Simmons] and Norman introduced me to Al and to Clark Terry, and that's where I met Junior, and then it turned out that Junior was a second degree black belt at the place I had just started taking karate.

MR: I did not know that.

VM: And those were the days when it was hard to get to black belt. I mean not that it's not hard now, but it was very physical, very hard core, more hard core than it is now on a fighting level. Yeah. So that was great, and he was such a nice guy, and obviously a great musician. I was so lucky, I met so many great people there and got to play with them. And then Norman introduced me to Al, he put me on a recording session of I don't know if it was Al or somebody else, and they just brought me in to just play the saxophone parts and then they were just going to bring in whoever to overdub the solos and stuff, and then they decided that I did such a good job quote unquote that they left me on the recording, and that was when Al started hiring me. So things were really popping at that point, I really was so lucky. And Joe Williams — what a nice guy.

MR: What changed in the New York scene from the time you arrived like and the next fifteen or twenty years?

VM: Well the New York scene, I mean there are a lot of different scenes. So you know there's the free scene, and if you're just talking about jazz okay, but then there are all the other things like salsa and everything, but in jazz there's the free scene and I played with this group called the Twelve Tone Funk Orchestra when I first got there, it was so much fun. But the straight ahead, you know the predominant jazz scene was basically a bebop scene. And that was when Wynton Marsalis and all the young lions came out and it was sort of like — when he came out it was sort of the people at the New School, the teachers and stuff referred to him sort of like the jazz police. This is the way, this is it, and they all wore suits and it was a very — he took what was sort of — I mean everybody did play bebop but he took what was like a more open thing and made it, I thought, and they thought, a much more rigid into the parameters. But bebop was king for sure when I moved to New York. And everybody played bebop and everybody that I — the people that I knew, the masters that I knew, and they had their own things but it was definitely bebop. And I started, I did an interview in the late 90s — oh I'm forgetting his name,

would regret later and I probably will but I'm going to say it again now and I said there's this thing happening — in 1998 — so that was a little over ten years after I moved there. I call it "Brooklyn White Boy" jazz. And it's exactly what it has become, you know, the end of swing and blues and digging in and that would be — I know I'm a nasty person but that is the biggest change is like the standard when I moved here in '87 was bebop was the standard. And now most of those people, now the people playing at the Village Vanguard are, I mean I would hesitate to say that to certain people but that's really the school they're in, they're in this sort of Brooklyn white boy jazz school, which is now the main — to me it's like it's esoteric and it's a lot of technique at all times and it doesn't have any blues in it, and not to say that they're not great musicians it's just I don't feel anything other than wow, that's amazing that he can do that.

MR: I think the key words you just said there was "at all times." Lots of technique at all times.

VM: Yeah. Right.

MR: But why Brooklyn? I don't know, I don't have a New York vibe. I don't know too much about it.

VM: Oh okay, already by the time I moved to New York most musicians had moved out to Brooklyn because of the rents. Not most, but many. And so that's where the young musicians in particular lived, in Brooklyn. And so that was sort of where the scene was.

MR: If we — I hope you don't mind me pursuing this because I like what you have to say about it, I think it's important. If you call it Brooklyn white boy jazz —

VM: Oh man.

MR: Yeah, what is — why is it white?

VM: Well when I came up, now this has changed also because now it's not just white people that play like that. When I came up the people that I liked to listen to were basically black and they had their roots in rhythm, they cared about the rhythm and the blues was a part of it. You know the swing was a part of it, the blues was a part of it, and this shift was almost completely white. And now there are some other people of color, but the basic push in that direction was usually white male, college graduates. And so that's why I called it that.

MR: Okay.

VM: So politically incorrect.

MR: No, but I've been over the years — adjudicated at many high school jazz festivals, and there's hardly any students of color in these things. Now that could be the suburban schools but it's not just that I don't think. And I see it at the college level, and I suppose the sociologists have opinions on it but I'm not sure why. What is it about this music that has less appeal?

VM: Well if you look at say even thirty years ago I was in my mid-twenties so my mom, when she was growing up — well my mom was white but that would have been the music of the time, the popular music that people of, the parents of people of my generation grew up with people still really liked jazz. You know? And the fans, the hard core fans that really knew everything, they were alive and they played the stuff for their kids and people grew up with it. But now the parents grew up in a world where it's not really, in general, as important I think. And so then you've got, let's see if there's a parent, if there's a 20-year-old and their parents were 20 when they had them so that would have been the 80s, late 70s that these people were born and they just don't have the history of it being as important, especially I think the internet has had a big influence on it also. The internet. Because I don't know it just seems like people used to, in my generation people would play records and everything is just really — family life, it just seems like with all the channels on Netflix and everything and just to sit around the house and have music it just seems like the whole society has changed and so that comes down on the parents of the kids that are going to college. Maybe — I don't know. I don't know who wants or doesn't want their kid to become a jazz musician but these days, I just spoke to somebody last week who was going to the New School and he said it's $40,000 a year.

MR: Yes. And that is much less than many places. I mean of course the cost of living on top of that in New York City, but many of the top universities are $20,000 more than that.

VM: How can anybody afford that? I mean other than — it's crazy.

MR: Yeah. And sometimes you wonder what all the jazz graduates are going to do.

VM: Come to New York.

MR: To Brooklyn.

VM: Well now everybody's moving to Queens now. Brooklyn has out-priced everybody.

MR: I see.

VM: So Queens is the new place.

MR: I see. I'll probably see an article about that in the Sunday *New York Times* pretty soon, in the magazine section.

VM: About the arts moving to Queens?

MR: Yes.

VM: Probably you will.

MR: I've enjoyed this a lot. What's a short list of your musical heroes?

VM: A short list?

MR: Yeah.

VM: Well I mean Sonny Rollins, Coltrane, Dexter Gordon, Joe Henderson, Lester Young, Kenny Garrett, Cannonball, Bird, and then Ingrid Jensen, Roberta Pickett, Victor Jones. I

continue to grow and I just I think they're inspiring you know and the music moves on. Coltrane's been dead how many decades? You know George Garzone, I love George Garzone. Do you know him?

MR: Yes.

VM: Yeah, yeah. And saxophone players, and it just — I mean I have my people that I grew up loving and at this point I mean I still love them of course but I just really love, of the people today that are creative within what I determine in my little world of jazz that I like.

MR: Let me try a name this tune on you.

VM: Oh goodness. I'm so bad at remembering the name of tunes. Are you going to play something for me?

MR: Well I'm so bad at trying to vocalize it so let me just get my [hums]. [Scats] wait hold on. [Scats]. Supposed to be in five.

VM: Oh okay.

MR: Have you got it?

VM: One-two-three-

MR: [Scats]

VM: Oh yeah. "Monterey Blues."

MR: You got it, yay. You move on to the next round.

VM: Boy you sure do your homework for these things.

MR: Well I love that tune and it's a great way to play something in five that still feels good.

VM: It's still cheerful.

MR: It's still cheerful.

VM: Yeah. I agree. I agree that they don't play anything in five like that these days. I'm so old, I mean I feel just like what happened? Twenty years ago there were a lot of people that felt — anyhow whatever.

MR: Well for the people who watch this I should mention that that's a composition of yours. Right?

VM: Yes. "Monterey Blues."

MR: And it's interesting that we've been talking about the blues and I just love the fact that the blues form is so adaptable. You can just never stop using it. You can put anything to it.

VM: Yep. Mess with it. Another — you know Monk tunes are also really good for that. Monk tunes, because they're so strong.

MR: Yeah.

VM: The melodies or the rhythms, you know the hits and stuff, they work really well with odd

MR: Yeah. Well here's not a softball question to sort of wrap up to. I'm interested in what artists have to think about the state of our country. So you could pass on the question but if you want to offer something I'd be happy to hear about it.

VM: Sure. I think we're in a very dark and dangerous point in our history right now with the anti-democratic, not just direction but I feel like we might even have a civil war because it just seems like what's been happening with the Republican party and the fact that they still embrace Trump after everything, it's just like they — are you a Republican?

MR: No.

VM: I hope not. They just — it's like they don't think and they're so angry and their morals, they have no morals. They'll do whatever it takes to get what they want. They'll cheat, they'll lie, they'll steal. And it was really an eye-opener when Trump got elected because I had no idea that there were that many people that would vote for somebody like that. I mean I knew they existed but I had no idea of the number. And what's happening with race I mean it's hard to — I guess that's a plus of the internet age and everybody having a camera on their phone, maybe we're just finding out more about this stuff. I mean I knew that there were issues but I had no idea that there's as much racism and hatred in this country. I mean I knew there was but not to the degree that it is. And then of course the whole thing with Russia — I mean Putin could set off a nuclear bomb at any time and then there's China. I think that that all contributes to me just wanting to do what I want to do, play the music I want to play with the great musicians I get to play with and what do you think?

MR: Yes it makes it all that much more valuable. And I'm — I've felt like I've been an optimist most of my life but it's harder and harder to be one now. And I agree with everything you've said and it seems like technology has brought out the worst in many people, the best in some but the worst in a lot of people. And it's okay to share all of it and try to convince others to be that way, because I can.

VM: I can. And you can find a little group of people, like-minded people, no matter what you're into you can find those people on the internet whereas before the internet you wouldn't find all these hundreds or thousands of people that think like you so you would keep it down. I don't know. I think we're in trouble.

MR: Yeah. Well let's think happy thoughts, like a major third against a minor blues.

VM: Only temporarily. Try it. Play like a little line and hit the minor third and then go up to the major third from it, and then go back down.

MR: Okay. I'm going to do it.

VM: It takes a little getting used to it but it's really a cool sound. Hey this has been so nice and I really appreciate it, and I hope I get to meet you in person one of these days.

VM: Good.

MR: All right. Thank you very much, Virginia, I'm going to sign out and then we'll say our good-byes.

VM: Okay. Should I stay here then?

MR: Just hang out for a bit.